He wasn't just a hero for me, then. It was my turn now. I stepped forward to the microphone. I'd gone over the few words I wanted to say again and again. I didn't want to be holding a piece of paper. I didn't want to be wondering what to say next. More first impressions were at stake here. I cleared my throat.

'Gracias. Senor Perez, Senor di Stefano, ladies and gentlemen…'

I left a split second for the translator to do his stuff. At first his microphone didn't seem to be working properly. I waited. And while I waited my mind went blank. Suddenly I was aware of the forest of cameras out in front of me, people around the hall craning heads in my direction. I'm glad I've learned to trust myself. I opened my mouth and the rest of it came.

'I have always loved soccer. Of course, I love my family…'

I looked down towards Victoria again: too right I love them.

'…and I have a wonderful life. But soccer is everything to me. To play for Real is a dream come true. Thank you to everyone for being here to share my arrival. Gracias.'

I held the shirt—my new shirt—up in front of me:

'Hala Madrid!'

The other directors of the club came over for the team photos and then Senor Perez led us offstage and back through the corridors to a room at the far end of the building, where there was a table laid out with tapas and biscuits and soft drinks. There's a room like this at every soccer club: a sloping ceiling and bench seats around the walls. They'd tidied this one up a bit, though. Then, I was taken through a door at the far end that led off into the dressing rooms: not quite as imposing as the ones at the Bernabeu the day before.

I took my time pulling on the Real Madrid uniform for the very first time. Then a couple of security guards and Simon and Jamie, from SFX, came through the dressing room and we walked across to Numero 2, a training field with low stands on one side and at one end, both crammed with supporters. It took a moment for my eyes to adapt, stepping outside into bright sunshine again. I ran through the gap in the fence and a couple of soccer balls were thrown towards me. I know I play for a living. Controlling a ball, keeping it up in the air, the odd trick: it's all second nature. But out on a patch of grass, in front of a couple of thousand supporters who are thinking: show us? It felt